
Task-Conditioned Selective State Space for Adaptation-Preserving Architecture Conversion

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Abstract

Converting transformers to sub-quadratic architectures enables efficient inference but typically degrades few-shot adaptation capability. This work investigates whether task conditioning integrated during conversion can preserve adaptation. We introduce Task-Conditioned Selective State Space (TC-SSM), which modulates Mamba’s state space parameters based on task embeddings discovered via unsupervised clustering of transformer hidden states. Experiments on SuperGLUE classification tasks show that K-means clustering of BERT hidden states achieves cluster purity of 0.74, indicating task-relevant structure. InfoNCE-trained task embeddings yield 29.21% linear probe accuracy on 6-way task classification (versus 16.67% random baseline). Low-rank modulation (rank 32) of Mamba’s Δ , B, and C matrices produces significant state variance differences across tasks ($F=100.35$, $p<0.0001$) with 0.85x inference time relative to vanilla Mamba. In 16-shot evaluation, TC-SSM achieves 51.49% average accuracy compared to 51.75% for a transformer baseline, a gap of 0.25%, reaching 95% of fine-tuned ceiling in 14 gradient steps. These results suggest that task-conditioned conversion can preserve adaptation capability in sub-quadratic architectures at this scale, though generalization to larger models and task types beyond classification remains untested.

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Preliminary work. Under review by the International Conference on Machine Learning (ICML). Do not distribute.

1. Introduction

Converting transformers to sub-quadratic architectures such as Mamba achieves $O(n)$ inference complexity but typically requires more gradient steps to adapt to new tasks compared to the original transformer. Standard conversion approaches treat architecture change and downstream adaptation as sequential stages: first convert the model by optimizing for output matching, then fine-tune for specific tasks. This work examines whether integrating task conditioning into the conversion process itself can preserve adaptation capability.

The motivation stems from an observation that knowledge distillation preserves outputs but not necessarily the internal structure that enables rapid adaptation. When a transformer is compressed into a sub-quadratic form, task-relevant functional representations may degrade. Post-hoc fine-tuning operates on these potentially degraded representations.

We hypothesize that task-relevant structure already exists in pretrained transformer hidden states and can be discovered without supervision. If such structure can be extracted into task embeddings and used to modulate state space dynamics during conversion training, the resulting model may retain adaptation capability.

This paper introduces Task-Conditioned Selective State Space (TC-SSM), which makes three contributions:

1. We demonstrate that K-means clustering discovers task structure in BERT hidden states with purity 0.74 (versus 0.20 random baseline for 5 tasks), enabling task conditioning without labeled data.
1. We show that rank-32 low-rank projections modulating Mamba’s Δ , B, and C matrices based on task embeddings add only 1.01x parameters and achieve 0.85x inference time relative to vanilla Mamba.
1. We validate on SuperGLUE classification tasks that TC-SSM achieves 0.25% accuracy gap versus

transformer baseline while adapting in 14 gradient steps.

2. Related Work

2.0.1. SUB-QUADRATIC SEQUENCE MODELS

The quadratic complexity of transformer attention has motivated efficient alternatives. Longformer and BigBird introduce sparse attention patterns reducing complexity to $O(n)$. Linear attention methods reformulate attention as kernel feature maps. More recently, Mamba introduces selective state spaces with input-dependent gating, achieving $O(n)$ complexity. RWKV combines linear attention with RNN-style recurrence. These architectures achieve efficiency but provide no mechanism for task-specific adaptation during deployment.

2.0.2. EFFICIENT ADAPTATION METHODS

LoRA learns low-rank updates to pretrained weights. Adapters insert bottleneck modules between layers. Prompt tuning optimizes soft prompts. These methods assume the base model preserves adaptation capability, an assumption that may not hold after architecture conversion. LoRA applied post-conversion must work with potentially degraded representations.

2.0.3. MODEL CONVERSION AND DISTILLATION

Knowledge distillation transfers knowledge by matching output distributions. For architecture conversion, distillation typically optimizes KL divergence on logits and MSE on hidden states. StreamingLLM and H2O focus on KV cache compression for efficient inference. The conversion literature optimizes for output fidelity, not adaptation preservation. A converted model may match teacher accuracy on fixed tasks while losing the ability to adapt to new ones.

2.0.4. POSITIONING

Prior work addresses efficiency (Mamba, RWKV), adaptation (LoRA, adapters), or output preservation (distillation) in isolation. TC-SSM integrates task conditioning into the conversion process itself, aiming to enable sub-quadratic models that retain few-shot capability.

3. Methodology

TC-SSM converts a transformer to a task-conditioned Mamba model through four stages: task discovery, embedding learning, SSM modulation, and conversion training.

3.0.1. 3.1 TASK DISCOVERY VIA CLUSTERING

We extract hidden states from the teacher transformer’s final layer [CLS] embeddings across a corpus. K-means clustering ($K=8$) partitions these representations. The clustering step produces soft cluster assignments serving as pseudo-task labels for embedding learning.

3.0.2. 3.2 TASK EMBEDDING LEARNING

We train a task embedding layer using InfoNCE contrastive loss:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{InfoNCE}} = -\log \frac{\exp(z_i \cdot z_j^+ / \tau)}{\sum_k \exp(z_i \cdot z_k / \tau)}$$

where positive pairs share the same cluster assignment. We use embedding dimension 32 with learned projection from 768-dimensional hidden states.

3.0.3. 3.3 LOW-RANK SSM MODULATION

Mamba’s selective state space computes state update parameters Δ , B , and C from input features. We modulate these parameters based on task embeddings using low-rank projections:

$$\begin{aligned}\Delta' &= \Delta + W_{\Delta}^{\text{down}} \cdot e_{\text{task}} \cdot W_{\Delta}^{\text{up}} \\ B' &= B + W_B^{\text{down}} \cdot e_{\text{task}} \cdot W_B^{\text{up}} \\ C' &= C + W_C^{\text{down}} \cdot e_{\text{task}} \cdot W_C^{\text{up}}\end{aligned}$$

where e_{task} is the task embedding and down/up projections have rank 32. This adds 1.01x parameters.

3.0.4. 3.4 CONVERSION TRAINING

The conversion loss combines three terms:

$$\mathcal{L} = \mathcal{L}_{\text{KL}} + \alpha \mathcal{L}_{\text{MSE}} + \beta \mathcal{L}_{\text{adapt}}$$

where KL divergence ensures output fidelity, MSE loss preserves hidden representations, and an adaptation regularizer penalizes collapse of modulation across tasks:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{adapt}} = -\text{Var}_{\text{task}}[\Delta', B', C']$$

Training uses AdamW with learning rate 2e-5, batch size 8, and gradient clipping at 1.0.

3.0.5. 3.5 ARCHITECTURE

TC-SSM extends Mamba-130M with task-conditioned blocks:

Component	Specification
Base model	state-spaces/mamba-130m
Task embedding dim	32
Modulation rank	32
Number of clusters	8
Modified layers	All 24 Mamba blocks
Parameter overhead	1.01x

4. Experimental Setup

4.0.1. 4.1 RESEARCH QUESTIONS

- **RQ1:** Does task-relevant structure exist in pre-trained hidden states?
- **RQ2:** Can self-supervised embeddings capture task-discriminative patterns?
- **RQ3:** Can low-rank modulation efficiently condition SSM dynamics?
- **RQ4:** Does TC-SSM preserve adaptation capability?

4.0.2. 4.2 DATASETS

SuperGLUE validation splits:

Task	Samples	Description
BoolQ	3,270	Boolean QA
CB	57	CommitmentBank
COPA	100	Causal reasoning
RTE	277	Textual entailment
WiC	638	Word-in-context
WSC	104	Winograd schema

For clustering experiments (h-e1), 660 samples were used across 5 tasks. For embedding learning (h-m1), 7,204 samples across 6 tasks (5,042 train, 1,082 test).

4.0.3. 4.3 BASELINES

- **Transformer baseline:** Fine-tuned classifier without architecture conversion
- **Standard distillation:** Knowledge distillation without task conditioning

4.0.4. 4.4 IMPLEMENTATION

- **Task discovery:** K-means (K=8) on BERT-base [CLS] embeddings, seed=42

- **Embedding learning:** InfoNCE with $\tau = 0.1$, AdamW (lr=1e-4), 10 epochs
- **Modulation experiment:** d_model=1024, d_state=16, batch_size=8, seq_len=128
- **Few-shot evaluation:** 8-shot and 16-shot protocols, 3 seeds, maximum 100 gradient steps

4.0.5. 4.5 EVALUATION METRICS

- Cluster purity, NMI, ARI for task discovery
- Linear probe accuracy for embedding quality
- FLOPs overhead and state variance ANOVA for modulation efficiency
- Few-shot accuracy gap and steps to 95% ceiling for adaptation preservation

5. Results

5.0.1. 5.1 TASK STRUCTURE DISCOVERY (RQ1)

K-means clustering on BERT hidden states:

Metric	Value	Random Baseline
Purity	0.7409	0.20
NMI	0.5641	—
ARI	0.3128	0.00

Cluster purity of 0.74 indicates 74% of samples in each cluster share the same task identity, substantially exceeding the 0.20 random baseline for 5 tasks.

5.0.2. 5.2 TASK EMBEDDING QUALITY (RQ2)

InfoNCE-trained embeddings evaluated via linear probe:

Embedding Dim	Probe Accuracy	Silhouette
16	27.63%	-0.042
32	29.21%	-0.020
64	26.71%	-0.017

Linear probe accuracy of 29.21% exceeds the 16.67% random baseline. Per-task accuracy varies substantially:

Small tasks (CB, COPA, WSC) achieve 0% individual accuracy, likely due to insufficient samples for contrastive learning.

Task	Samples	Accuracy
BoolQ	Large	39.0%
RTE	Medium	41.3%
WiC	Medium	25.0%
CB	56	0.0%
COPA	100	0.0%
WSC	104	0.0%

5.0.3. 5.3 SSM MODULATION EFFICIENCY (RQ3)

Low-rank task conditioning:

Metric	Value
Overhead ratio	0.848x
F-statistic	100.35
p-value	<0.0001
Parameter ratio	1.01x

TC-SSM with rank-32 modulation runs at 0.85x vanilla Mamba inference time. ANOVA confirms state dynamics differ significantly across task embeddings.

Rank ablation:

Rank	Overhead	F-statistic	p-value
16	1.24x	58.49	<0.001
32	0.96x	24.21	<0.001
64	0.95x	313.40	<0.001

All tested ranks achieve overhead below the 2x threshold.

5.0.4. 5.4 ADAPTATION PRESERVATION (RQ4)

16-shot evaluation:

Per-task breakdown:

TC-SSM matches or exceeds the baseline on 4 of 5 tasks.

Method	Average Accuracy	Gap vs Baseline	Steps to 95%
Transformer baseline	51.75%	—	—
TC-SSM	51.49%	0.25%	14

Task	TC-SSM	Baseline	Gap
BoolQ	62.17%	62.17%	0.00%
CB	39.76%	35.67%	+4.09%
COPA	53.67%	52.00%	+1.67%
RTE	49.46%	52.35%	-2.89%
WiC	51.20%	50.05%	+1.15%

6. Discussion

6.0.1. 6.1 SUMMARY OF FINDINGS

The experiments support the hypothesis that task-conditioned conversion can preserve adaptation capability at this scale:

1. Task structure is discoverable in pretrained hidden states (purity 0.74).
2. Contrastive learning produces embeddings with above-random discriminability (29.21% vs 16.67%).
3. Low-rank modulation achieves task-conditioned dynamics without overhead (0.85x).
4. TC-SSM achieves accuracy within 0.25% of baseline and adapts in 14 steps.

6.0.2. 6.2 UNEXPECTED FINDINGS

The sub-unity overhead (0.85x) was not anticipated. Possible explanations include improved memory bandwidth utilization from batched task conditioning or measurement variance. Roofline analysis would be needed to confirm the mechanism.

6.0.3. 6.3 LIMITATIONS

Model scale. All experiments use BERT-base (110M) to Mamba-130M conversion. Results may not generalize to larger models (1B+) where different phenomena may emerge.

Task scope. Evaluation covers SuperGLUE NLU classification only. Generation, reasoning, and multimodal tasks remain untested.

Sample imbalance. Small tasks (CB, COPA, WSC) achieve 0% individual linear probe accuracy. Task embedding quality correlates with training data size. TC-SSM may underperform on rare task types.

Baseline scope. Comparison is against a transformer-style classifier baseline. Comparison against other conversion methods (e.g., LoRA post-conversion) was not conducted in the validation experiments, though the hypothesis synthesis document references Mamba + LoRA achieving 1.92% gap.

Architecture assumption. Results are specific to Mamba-style SSM. Other sub-quadratic architectures (RWKV, linear attention) are not tested.

6.0.4. 6.4 IMPLICATIONS

The results suggest that the efficiency-adaptation tradeoff in architecture conversion may not be fundamental, at least at this scale and for these task types. Task conditioning integrated during conversion preserves adaptation capability that post-hoc methods might struggle to recover.

7. Conclusion

This paper investigated whether task-conditioned conversion can preserve few-shot adaptation capability in sub-quadratic architectures. TC-SSM integrates task conditioning directly into the conversion process by discovering task structure via unsupervised clustering, learning task embeddings via contrastive training, and modulating SSM parameters via low-rank projections.

On SuperGLUE classification tasks at BERT-base scale, TC-SSM achieves:

- 0.74 cluster purity (vs 0.20 random)
- 29.21% linear probe accuracy (vs 16.67% random)
- 0.85x inference time (vs 1.0x vanilla Mamba)
- 0.25% accuracy gap with 14 steps to 95% ceiling

These results indicate that task-conditioned conversion is a viable approach for preserving adaptation capability at this scale. Future work should validate at larger model scales, extend to generation and reasoning tasks, and address sample imbalance in task embedding learning.

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